Language and communication

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Language and how we communicate (163 words)

Language is the most powerful tool people have for sharing ideas. Within one country, a regional **dialect** or a distinctive **accent** can reveal where a speaker comes from. A **bilingual** speaker moves easily between two languages, and a **fluent** speaker uses **grammar**, **vocabulary** and **pronunciation** with confidence. A **native speaker** may still struggle with an unfamiliar **idiom** or with informal **slang**.

Communication is not only spoken. **Non-verbal** signals, including **body language**, often **convey** more than words, and **sign language** has its own grammar. Every writing **script** has an **origin** in earlier forms, and the Arabic script, for example, is written from right to left. A high **literacy rate** is a sign of a country's educational success.

Problems arise when messages are misunderstood. A single **miscommunication** can lead to a serious dispute, so skilled people **interpret** carefully and check meaning. A professional **translation** needs both accuracy and tact, and machine tools, though impressive, still **fall short of** a skilled human, as they often **miss the point**.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
fall short of	do not reach the standard of
miss the point	fail to see the real meaning

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
dialect	n	a form of a language used in one region	*The northern dialect sounds different.*
bilingual	adj	able to speak two languages	*Bilingual children switch easily.*
accent	n	the way a person pronounces words	*She has a slight French accent.*
vocabulary	n	all the words a person knows	*Reading builds vocabulary.*
grammar	n	the rules of a language	*Grammar errors lower the score.*
translation	n	changing words into another language	*Machine translation has improved.*
non-verbal	adj	without words	*Non-verbal communication includes gestures.*
body language	n	messages sent by movements	*Body language shows confidence.*

literacy rate	n	the percentage of people who can read	*The literacy rate is over ninety percent.*
fluent	adj	able to speak easily	*He is fluent in three languages.*
native speaker	n	a person who learned the language as a child	*A native speaker corrected her.*
idiom	n	a fixed phrase with a special meaning	*"Break a leg" is an idiom.*
slang	n	very informal words	*Teenagers invent new slang.*
script	n	a system of writing	*The Arabic script is written right to left.*
sign language	n	communication using hand signs	*Sign language has its own grammar.*
origin	n	the place where something begins	*The origin of the word is Latin.*
pronunciation	n	the way a word is said	*Correct pronunciation helps understanding.*
interpret	v	to translate speech at once	*She interpreted for the delegation.*
miscommunication	n	a failure to communicate clearly	*Miscommunication caused the delay.*
convey	v	to express a message	*The poster conveys a clear idea.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
invention	n	a new thing created by someone
prototype	n	the first model of a product
mechanism	n	the parts of a machine that work together
efficiency	n	doing something with little waste
durable	adj	strong and lasting a long time
renewable energy	n	energy from sources that do not run out
turbine	n	a machine that turns movement into power
circuit	n	a path for electricity
blueprint	n	a detailed plan of a design
manufacture	v	to make goods in large numbers

Practice: fill the gaps

translation · literacy rate · pronunciation · non-verbal · slang · convey · script · grammar

1. Machine _____ has improved.
2. The _____ is over ninety percent.

3. Correct _____ helps understanding.

4. _____ communication includes gestures.

5. Teenagers invent new _____.

6. The poster _____ a clear idea.

7. The Arabic _____ is written right to left.

8. _____ errors lower the score.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

abbreviation (n): a shortened form of a word
alphabet (n): a set of letters
ambiguous (adj): having more than one meaning
articulate (adj): able to express ideas clearly
bilingualism (n): using two languages
borrowing (n): a word taken from another language
catchphrase (n): a popular saying
clarity (n): clearness
colloquial (adj): used in informal speech
comprehension (n): understanding
conversation (n): a talk between people
dialogue (n): a conversation
eloquent (adj): good at speaking
expression (n): a phrase or look
formal (adj): serious and correct in style
gesture (n): a movement that gives a message
gist (n): the main point
informal (adj): relaxed in style
intonation (n): the rise and fall of the voice
jargon (n): special words used by a group
linguist (n): a person who studies languages
mother tongue (n): the first language
mumble (v): to speak unclearly
nuance (n): a small difference in meaning
offensive (adj): insulting
persuasive (adj): able to convince
register (n): the style of language used
rhetorical (adj): used to impress
syllable (n): a unit of sound in a word
tone (n): the quality of a voice

Answers

1. translation (translation)
2. literacy rate (literacy rate)
3. pronunciation (pronunciation)
4. Non-verbal (non-verbal)
5. slang (slang)
6. conveys (convey)
7. script (script)
8. Grammar (grammar)